I'm Jealous of the Moon

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I'm Jealous of the Moon

by Intensely_Reading

Summary

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>
> He feels a sharp flick to his forehead. Phainon flinches, eyes lifting to meet Mydei’s scowl. Despite the severe expression, there’s a slight flush to his cheeks—his golden eyes shifting from Phainon’s gaze. Something in Phainon sinks like a stone.
>
> “Have you no propriety, Deliverer?” Mydei asks. “Did no one teach you any manners?”
>
> Phainon forces out a sheepish laugh, his smile unsteady.
>
> “My apologies,” he says.
>
> (Phainon doesn’t think there’s anything more pathetic than being jealous of a dead man.)

Notes

> If you squint hard enough, you can see me projecting my undying love for Mydei onto Phainon.

See the end of the work for more notes

He's aware of how childish this is.

Gods is he aware.

He hates the way his skin burns like a fever—blood thrumming in a disgusting mix of shame and frustration. He hates the ugly feeling in his gut that twists his insides into knots until the sick sensation spreads like a disease. He would rather Nikador strike him down, over and over again, than admit he's feeling all of this, admit he's this terribly desperate. This selfish. This *needy*.

After all, who would be jealous of a dead man?

But there's something in the way Mydei speaks of his old friends—something in the way his lips curl around their names, like he's cradling something priceless in the lilt of his tone. There's something personal in the gleam of his eyes—a distant expression that's too far for Phainon to reach. There's something hidden in his smile that speaks of the grief and the loss, but also the love young Mydeimos must've had for the five people he traipsed Amphoreus with, a love that old Mydeimos has carried with him up until this moment now.

It's something innocent, something clear and true. It's so very Mydei to smile when he thinks of his close friends rather than ache like an open wound—to look back with nothing but honesty and love. And Phainon is happy for him, initially. He's happy and maybe envious, but mostly happy that Mydei can reminisce on those he's lost and only remember the good times, even if things ended badly.

(He wishes he could be the same. He wishes he could look back and remember the smiles of his family and his friends. But when he remembers, he remembers their screams, the blackness in the air, and the acrid smell of burning flesh.)

But then, something shifts on Mydei's face when he mentions the friend that stayed with him the longest, something like sorrow or regret or pain. And Phainon's watching so closely that he sees the small crease between Mydei's brows deepen and hears the way his voice drops in pitch like the words are meant for something more delicate than just simple reminiscing. It reels Phainon in—the intimacy Mydei seems to be encouraging, and the greedy part of him is hungry for even a small scrap of closeness.

"My most trusted friend, Hephaestion… He was supposed to stand by my side through it all, but a sudden relapse of his illness hit him on the eve of my duel against my father…"

Nikador's strife, Phainon feels *sick*. He physically feels his stomach drop, his body splattering to the ground, spilling its disgusting mess all over the Garden of Life for Mydei to witness.

Mydei's *most trusted friend*. He wonders what it feels like to hold such an honor. Dearest friend, closest companion, the one Mydei begged to stay, refused to let go. The one who holds Mydei's love so closely that it physically pains Mydei to remember him—that his voice

lowers into something quiet, something hurt, something more appropriate for a private room than in the Garden of Life with the public as witness and Kephale in the distance.

“You two were the last ones left,” Phainon says past the lump in his throat—swallowing down the bitterness on his tongue. “Of course, you’d be close.”

Mydei huffs. He’s looking towards Phainon but not really looking at him. Phainon wants to know what Mydei sees instead. He wants to know if it’s Hephaestion he’s imagining with how intimately he’s speaking. Phainon wants to grip Mydei’s shoulders and make him focus on *him* instead. He doesn’t want second-hand intimacy from Mydei.

(He settles for it anyway. He settles because he’s still that young kid from Aedes Elysiae who had love yanked from him all too quickly. And he’s always been a greedy thing for Mydei’s attention—for the feeling of sunlight on his skin—promising him he would be okay.)

“I suppose you are right,” Mydei says. “Even on his deathbed, Hephaestion was worried about me. He did not want me to shed tears for him. Thought it unbecoming of a king.”

“Did you?” Phainon asks, the question falling from his lips before he can stop himself. “Cry for him… I mean.”

“Of course I did,” Mydei says, sounding a touch regretful—like it pains him to admit he failed his closest, dearest, most trusted companion. “I haven’t shed a tear since.”

Phainon swallows down his next words, throwing the blanket over his most shameful thoughts—squirreling away the attention-seeking side of him that badgers Mydei into every competition they enter.

(If, on the battlefield, Phainon died, would Mydei shed tears for him?)

Part of Phainon is grateful for the distraction when Tribbie comes sprinting towards the two of them, shouting, “Little De! Little De! We’ve got a big problem!” It draws Mydei’s eyes away from him so he can breathe again, gasping breaths like he’s breaking for air.

The other part of him is hungry for more information about this “Hephaestion,” to know how highly Mydei regards him, to bear witness to how deep their bond was that even after all this time, Mydei looks back on his memory like it aches. To know if Phainon stands a chance.

(Or if he ever stood a chance.)

His curtains are already shut. He has his arm over his eyes to block out the remaining light when his door creaks open. He hears someone padding towards him, stopping by the foot of the bed. The clink of armor being removed sounds in the quiet, followed by the rustling of clothes being taken off and the sheets being lifted. Phainon’s breath catches like it always

does whenever Mydei gets so close that he can feel his warmth next to him—his mere presence settling his thoughts like a balm to his anxieties.

Mydei sighs as he settles next to him, the sound heavy like the weight he carries. Phainon deepens his breathing, pretending he's already asleep.

"I know you aren't asleep, Deliverer," Mydei drawls, the words low and quiet. Phainon stiffens.

"No, you don't," Phainon says, petulant.

"Sleeping men don't tend to speak," Mydei says, his words curling into something wry. "Stop pretending."

"I could be sleeping talking."

"You don't talk in your sleep."

"How do you know that?"

"Because you *snore*, Deliverer. You snore when you sleep." Phainon lifts his arm, shooting Mydei a withering glare. Mydei only snorts. "That's how I know you aren't asleep."

"I don't snore," Phainon retorts, propping himself up so he's eye-level with the Crown Prince. Mydei raises a singular brow.

Admittedly, there are a lot of things Phainon would back down on for Mydei's sake. There are a lot of things Phainon would give to Mydei just to have his eyes on him, to have him direct that soft smile at him like he's done something worthy of his respect.

Wins in petty arguments aren't one of them.

(Every win against Mydei is proof that he needs Phainon just as much as Phainon needs him.)

"You've been quiet since action hour," Mydei says, expression flattening into something serious—something that makes Phainon's chest throb and his stomach drop. "What's causing our Deliverer to think so hard?"

Phainon laughs—the sound tapering awkwardly at the ends like he's not sure how to hold himself. He sits up fully, leaning against the headboard so he's looking down on Mydei.

"Nothing's causing me to think," Phainon says, smiling stiffly. "It's just been a long day, I suppose. Can you blame me after what happened at the Grove? After what Castorice, Trianne, and the Trailblazer found there?"

Mydei's eyes rove his face, staring up at Phainon. Phainon meets his gaze, tracking the way Mydei's lips flatten, pressing together like he's picking his next words carefully. Sometimes, when Mydei's eyes are on him like this, Phainon feels as if he's baring his soul for judgment—for Mydei to find the hairline cracks in his flawless Chrysos Heir soul and seal him back into something just a little more whole.

For the Crown Prince of a warmongering, Strife-following kingdom, Mydei has always had such gentle hands. He has always been someone who built others up rather than tore them down.

(His eyes flicker to Mydei's hands, resting just a few inches from his own. His fingers twitch.)

"Deliverer," Mydei starts, drawing out the nickname, "I told you of my past—my old comrades—because I trust you. I wanted you to know more about me."

His lips part. He swallows roughly, hands flexing over the sheets. The way Mydei is staring now makes his body burn something fierce. He feels hungry, always hungry—like a withering plant that needs the sunlight to survive. It doesn't help that even without Mydei saying his name, the mere reference to Hephaestion makes that same bitterness spread in his mouth like a poison.

"I won't ever expect you to explain yourself if you do not feel comfortable," Mydei continues. His fingers slot between Phainon's on the bed, always the braver one between the two of them where it matters. "But, I do hope you know we care about you, Phainon. Whatever it is that ails you, I want to know in case I can help."

A breathless sort of laugh escapes his lips. He takes Mydei's hand and grips tight. The ugly feeling sits in his gut, spilling over his insides until he's stained green with envy and want. Honestly, it was presumptuous of him to assume Mydei didn't have old flames—dead or not. He is kind, and honorable, and *Titans* is he handsome. He's so handsome it makes Phainon ache. He could have anyone, realistically, even if Phainon knows Mydei doesn't want just anyone.

Maybe the root of this is the realization that he isn't the only one Mydei's chosen to hold a torch for.

(He isn't even the first one.)

"You and Hephaestion," Phainon starts, soft. He averts his gaze, staring at their linked hands. "You speak of him highly. Did anything come from that?"

Mydei huffs, the sound one part amused, three parts melancholic.

"No," he says. "No, it didn't. We… well. It would've never worked out at the time."

"Why not?" Phainon asks—demands.

"We were exiles, Deliverer. We were always fighting to survive. And while I wouldn't have cared, Hephaestion was very aware of my position as Crown Prince."

"So you two never, say, fell into the same cot together?"

He feels a sharp flick to his forehead. Phainon flinches, eyes lifting to meet Mydei's scowl. Despite the severe expression, there's a slight flush to his cheeks—his golden eyes shifting from Phainon's gaze. Something in Phainon sinks like a stone.

“Have you no propriety, Deliverer?” Mydei asks. “Did no one teach you any manners?”

Phainon forces out a sheepish laugh, his smile unsteady.

“My apologies,” he says. “I didn’t realize Castrum Kremnos’ Prince was a blushing maiden.”

“Most people don’t ask about others’ escapades so freely,” Mydei drawls. “How would you react if I asked you to list all your past affairs?”

“I would tell you there are none,” Phainon blurts out. Mydei’s gaze jumps to him, brows raised in surprise. “There were none before this.”

“Really?”

Phainon winces at the incredulity coloring Mydei’s tone. Something flares in his chest like a lit match to oil, encouraging him to rear his fangs at this nonexistent threat.

“Was I supposed to?” he asks, defensive.

“No, that’s not what I meant.” Mydei sits up too so he’s at eye-level with Phainon. It rattles him even more that he’s no longer looking down at Mydei, hackles rising like he’s protecting a hidden wound. “I only meant that I’m surprised no one’s caught your eye.”

“Caught my eye?”

Mydei nods.

“You are handsome, intelligent, and well-put together, Deliverer,” Mydei says, lips quirked. “I was merely surprised you’ve never accepted someone else's advances before.”

Phainon blinks.

“I don’t— I haven’t— I… ah.” His words stumble over themselves, torn between embarrassed that Mydei believes he’s a catch, and preening because… because Mydei believes he’s a catch. “I guess I just… never felt the need to. Not after everyone I loved died.”

Mydei’s expression sobers immediately, nodding once. He squeezes Phainon’s hand, the warmth of his hold seeping into Phainon’s cold core.

“I understand,” Mydei says, quiet. “Outside of Hephaestion, I had no interest in pursuing anyone back then either.”

The start of a question forms on the tip of his tongue, something cruel to both of them—a poison-laced question. He shouldn’t ask, but the curiosity burns in his chest like a knife twisting in him, striking at the parts he hides the best because what would the world say if they realized their Deliverer was just as selfish and needy and insecure as anyone else.

“If Hephaestion hadn’t died from illness,” he says, the regret already crashing on him the moment he starts to ask. But he *has* to know—*needs* to know if he would have stood any sort

of chance, “do you think something would’ve happened then?”

(He presses the knife harder—all his insecurities spilling between the two of them for Mydei to witness.)

“Why?” Mydei asks, brow raised and eyes narrowed curiously.

Phainon shrugs, the action stiff.

“Curiosity, I guess,” he says, quiet. “If there was a chance, would you?”

Mydei stares. He averts his gaze, expression distant—lost in thought. Phainon grips onto Mydei’s hand tighter like he’ll somehow lose the other if he doesn’t hold on now.

“I don’t know,” Mydei admits, still not looking at Phainon. “Maybe.”

(Phainon shudders.)

The thing about Mydei is that he inspires confidence by simply existing.

Phainon would be hard-pressed to explain how or why—only because it’s a million little things about Mydei that amass into someone like him. His conviction, his assurance, his honor, all of it have been perfectly placed together to bring those around him the greatest sense of safety, even in the midst of a battle—*especially* in the midst of a battle.

And after everything Phainon has experienced, there is nothing safer to him than someone who cannot die. There is no one Phainon relies on more these days than Mydei, and he is painfully aware of it. Between the two of them, Phainon is the one who pulls them forward towards the next mission, the next challenge, the next competition. Mydei is the one who ensures they survive everything Phainon pulls them through, the one who pulls him together when the world seems to press him down.

If Mydei were the ground they stood on, supporting life as they knew it, Phainon would be the waves, crashing against the earth again and again—if only to be that much closer, to stay that much longer. He’s aware he needs Mydei more than Mydei relies on him. He is *always* looking back to make sure the other is just a single step behind.

(Mydei has always been just a single step behind him for so long, Phainon’s forgotten to look back these days.)

That’s why the existence of Hephaestion is so unsettling. It’s the fact that there had been someone else Mydei considered his equal in every sense of the word, someone else who could give Mydei something he wanted around, someone else who is not Phainon on Amphoreus’ titan-forsaken land that could capture Mydei’s care and hold fast to it. There was

someone who was all of Mydei's firsts, who spent ten years with Mydei, who saw him at his lowest and watched him become the man he is today.

He wonders if Hephaestion had to trail Mydei like a puppy to get him to notice him. He wonders if Hephaestion had to compete with Mydei every day just to have an excuse to see him. He wonders if it was effortless on Hephaestion's part to gain Mydei's attention. He wonders if Hephaestion was a kind and honorable man, deserving to stand as Mydei's dearest friend.

Because Phainon, at the end of the day, is possessive.

(He is insecure.)

He is greedy.

(He is needy.)

He is selfish.

(He is far too attached.)

He is far removed from the faultless Deliverer, especially when it comes to Mydei. And could anyone blame him? It's Mydei, after all. And he may be the Deliverer, but it is Mydei that inspires confidence. It is Mydei that keeps him steady. It is Mydei that lets his shoulders relax and his smiles stretch wide and his laughs breathless. It has always been Mydei.

(Isn't it pathetic to hold so much jealousy for a dead man?)

Between the two of them, Phainon is usually the one seeking Mydei out. It's not hard; the prince prefers routine more often than not, so Phainon's first spot to look is always the rooftop in Marmoreal Market that Mydei enjoys overlooking from. He told Phainon, years ago, that it's because it was quiet and secluded and the silence there allowed him a moment to think and simply be.

Phainon, on the other hand, doesn't often hide. He enjoys being around people and mingling with the crowd. But when he doesn't want to be found, he'd like to think he's rather good at hiding himself.

(He's had a lot of practice too—hiding himself.)

It's rarer still for Mydei to seek him out, searching through Okhema to find him amongst the crowds. When he hears the sound of armored boots walking across the rooftops, he's half-expecting some dry comment about Phainon stealing Mydei's quiet spot for himself.

"So this is where you've been, Deliverer."

Phainon glances to his right in surprise, watching Mydei lower himself next to him, sitting down on the edge of the roof. His heat radiates out like that of a fireplace, offering comfort by simply existing in the same space. Phainon lets his eyes trail up to Mydei's face, finding the other already watching him with a sharpness to his eyes.

"Here I am," Phainon says, aiming for grandiose and falling miles flat from it. He smiles, wide and crumbling. "What does the Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos need from me?"

Mydei frowns.

"You've been acting odd lately, Deliverer," he says. "And stop smiling like that. It hurts to watch."

"Ouch." Phainon lets his smile drop. He curls in on himself, guiding his gaze back towards Okhema proper. "You didn't answer my question. What did you need me for?"

"Am I not allowed to wonder where you've gone when I haven't seen a hint of you all day?"

"We've gone days without seeing each other before, Mydeimos," Phainon says. "You make it sound like we spend every waking moment together."

"Do we not?" Mydei asks. "I was under the impression that you enjoyed trailing after me like a puppy."

Phainon's eye twitches. He snorts.

"Is that what I am to you?" he asks humorlessly. "A lost puppy?"

Mydei goes quiet—the kind of quiet that presses down on the air like a tangible force. Phainon feels something shrivel in him, his heart bleeding out in front of him in a slow death. It isn't Mydei's fault he's so insecure that even the hint of Mydei's other love interests makes him bare his fangs. It isn't Mydei's fault he's always hungry for his presence. It isn't Mydei's fault he's jealous of someone he's never met and never will because they were long gone before Phainon ever entered the picture.

It isn't Mydei's fault that he is beloved. All things yearn for the sun, after all. Even the moon.

"What has gotten into you?" Mydei asks sharply.

His hand grabs the front of Phainon's shirt, pulling him forward with surprising force. Phainon flinches, forced to face the brunt of Mydei's scowl.

"You keep staring at me like you've lost something, HKS," he says, his words ending in a frustrated growl. The furrow between his brows deepens, worry immediately softening the severity of his expression. Phainon's almost certain Mydei doesn't realize how easily he sheds his anger for worry, but every time it happens, he feels himself melt—a selfish part of him hoping Mydei only acts like this with him. "What has your head spinning circles around itself like this?"

Phainon stares. He lifts his hands, gently prying Mydei's fingers off his shirt only to cradle Mydei's hand between his. His hands are cold compared to Mydei's, the heat addicting against his skin.

"Nothing's wrong."

Mydei narrows his eyes.

"Deliverer," he says, voice dry, "you are a terrible liar."

"I'm not—"

"Phainon," Mydei interrupts, raising a singular brow his way. Phainon stills, biting hard on the inside of his cheek. He averts his eyes, chest burning. It clogs his throat like he's suffocating from the vapors, the bitter taste of ash clinging to the back of his mouth.

"It's stupid," he says.

"It's not stupid if it has you so worked up."

Phainon winces.

"Mydeimos," he says, soft, "it might not seem like it most of the time, but I do actually care about how you view me. For my sake, please let this go."

"There's little you could do or say that would change how I see you, Phainon."

The words wring his insides—squeezing his chest until it aches. He squeezes his eyes shut, gripping Mydei's hand tightly. Between the two of them, Phainon is the more stubborn one. Phainon is the insistent one. Phainon is the one who holds his insecurities close. Normally, simple platitudes wouldn't sway him so easily. But he's frustrated with himself, and he's tense, and maybe he *has* been running in circles for too long—tripping over his own shame trying to hide how much he wants.

He sucks in his next breath.

"I'm *jealous* of your comrade, Mydei. That's it." He opens his eyes, watching surprise flash across Mydei before his expression turns frighteningly neutral. Phainon feels his body tense as adrenaline courses through him. He runs a rough hand through his hair, laughing nervously.

"I'm jealous of Hephaestion for taking all your firsts," he says, words falling from his lips until he's a rambling mess. "I'm jealous that he had a chance to be with you before I did. I'm jealous that there *had* been someone else in the first place. I'm jealous, and I'm possessive, and I've been running circles in my mind because I can't believe I've reached such a low that I'm envious of someone who's already gone. But no matter how much I rationalize and compartmentalize and overthink, I'm still upset that there had been someone else in your life before me."

Mydei frowns, and something in Phainon shirks from the sight—hiding from whatever look the other must be giving him. He looks down at their linked hands. Part of him wonders if he should let go for both their sakes, even if he detests the idea with his whole being.

“Is that all?”

“What?” Phainon says, stunned. He lifts his head.

“Is that all?” Mydei repeats—golden eyes piercing.

Phainon blinks. Reluctantly, he nods.

Mydei sighs. He untangles his hand from Phainon’s only to grab his arm and pull him in—arms wrapping tightly around him. Phainon freezes, breath caught in his throat as he feels Mydei shift against him, securing his hold. It only takes a matter of seconds for Phainon to give in, burying his head in the other’s shoulder and gripping him just as tightly. This close, he can smell the scent of pomegranates and honey on Mydei when he breathes in, so familiar it aches. The acid in his gut that’s been in him slowly settles the longer Mydei holds him—the closeness appeasing the needy, greedy part of him. His shoulders slump, exhaling deep like he’s been holding his breath for days.

“And here I thought you murdered someone,” Mydei murmurs, his hot breath ghosting his ear.

“What?” he says, choked.

“You acted like you did something unspeakable, Deliverer, not moping because you were stuck in your head for too long.”

“I wasn’t moping,” Phainon says petulantly. He clutches Mydei impossibly tighter, digging his nose into the crook of Mydei’s neck. Mydei grunts. “You don’t understand how hard it is to be me when you’re *you*.”

His words are a muffled mess while he tries to bury himself in Mydei’s scent and Mydei’s heat and Mydei’s presence further—hopelessly carving a place next to Mydei’s heart for himself. He feels the warm pressure of lips against the crown of his head and a soft huff of amusement ruffles the strands of his hair.

“I won’t lie and say there wasn’t anything,” Mydei admits, a touch wistful. Phainon squeezes him tight enough for Mydei’s breath to hitch. “It would be a disservice to protect your feelings like that. But, I can tell you there is no one else I would rather spend my time with now than you, Phainon. There is no competition when it comes to you. It is as simple as that.”

Phainon stills. He turns his head, eyes lifting to meet Mydei’s. The Kremnoan’s lips are curved in a soft smile, expression relaxed and eyes gentle. Phainon feels his chest ache for entirely different reasons, gaze tracking the way Mydei’s lips curve higher for him.

“I don’t think you understand what that means to me, Mydei,” he says, hushed. His blood roars in his ears, hungry—always hungry—for the sunlight.

“I thought I was rather unambiguous,” Mydei says, raising a brow. “There is no one else. Only you.”

Phainon tackles Mydei to the ground, looming over him. Mydei stares up at him, amused.

“You know you could have anyone,” Phainon murmurs, deathly serious. “Anyone would be foolish to say no to someone like you, Mydeimos.”

“I hope you aren’t foolish then, Deliverer,” Mydei challenges. His arms rise. Before Phainon can react, Mydei pulls him down—hands splayed over the sides of his face. His lips press against Phainon’s, the kiss short and hard, ending before Phainon registers what happened. He blinks down at Mydei when they part, mouth parted and tasting pomegranates on his lips.

Mydei snorts.

“That… that was unfair,” Phainon argues weakly, cheeks pink. “You’re playing dirty, Crown Prince.”

“How so?”

“You can’t kiss me before I answer you,” he says, running his mouth aimlessly just to talk—just to make Mydei laugh. “Who knows? Maybe I am an idiot and won’t accept.”

“My apologies for assuming too much from you then.”

“Exactly. This is all your fault, Mydei.” Phainon’s eyes flicker to Mydei’s lips again, breath quickening. “If you weren’t so *you*, I wouldn’t have felt so miserable these past few days.”

Mydei’s smile widens. Phainon kisses that smile off, capturing it between his lips—claiming this treasure entirely for his own. The other’s hands comb through his hair and gently tugs, sending shivers down Phainon’s spine. He cups the other’s jaw, tilting his head, kissing Mydei until his lungs strain for air. And when they part, he refuses to stray far, lowering himself so his head rests atop Mydei’s chest. His arms wrap tightly around Mydei, the tension in his body seeping out until all he feels is warm and pliant.

Mydei’s hands stay in his hair, aimlessly combing through his strands. Phainon lets his eyes close and sighs.

“You aren’t good at hiding your emotions, Deliverer,” he hears Mydei murmur above him, voice low and hushed—encouraging an intimacy that is strictly for Phainon only. “I knew you were upset. I was waiting for you to come to me about it. But all you did was ask odd questions and become more and more like a kicked puppy the longer I let it happen.”

Phainon pinches Mydei. Mydei flinches, swatting the top of his head.

“You *like* this kicked puppy,” he says arrogantly, prouder about this than he thinks he should be.

Mydei's sigh sounds bone-weary. Phainon chuckles, burying his head against Mydei's chest. He rests his ear just above Mydei's heart, listening to its steady drum.

"I love you," Mydei murmurs, whispering in his ear like it's a secret just for him.

Phainon's arms tighten around the other, heart shaking like a leaf. He licks his lips and tastes pomegranates and honey on his tongue—feeling, for once, content.

End Notes

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